Ratha Yatra

The Festival of Chariots

A Journey of the Gods

Ratha Yatra, literally the "chariot journey," is one of the oldest and most spectacular festivals in Hindu tradition. Once a year, temple deities who are normally kept behind closed sanctum doors are brought out into the open and paraded through public streets on towering, hand-built wooden chariots, allowing every worshipper — regardless of caste or status — to have darshan, a sacred glimpse of the divine.

The Puri Tradition

The most famous Ratha Yatra takes place in Puri, Odisha, centered on Lord Jagannath, a form of Krishna, along with his elder brother Balabhadra and sister Subhadra. Each year, usually in the Hindu month of Ashadha (June–July), the three deities are carried from the Jagannath Temple to the Gundicha Temple, about three kilometers away, where they "reside" for a week before returning in a second procession called Bahuda Yatra.

Three enormous chariots are freshly constructed each year from wood, using traditional carpentry with no metal nails. Jagannath's chariot, Nandighosa, stands roughly 13 meters tall and is pulled through the streets by thousands of devotees, an act believed to bring immense spiritual merit. The event draws vast crowds and is one of the largest public gatherings in the world.

Meaning and Reach

Symbolically, the festival represents the deity stepping out to meet ordinary people rather than waiting for them to come to the temple — a gesture of accessibility and equality at the heart of the tradition. Similar Ratha Yatra celebrations, on a smaller scale, are held at temples across India and Nepal, including Thiruvarur in Tamil Nadu and Patan in Nepal.

Since the 1960s, the International Society for Krishna Consciousness (ISKCON) has carried the festival worldwide, organizing Ratha Yatra processions in cities such as London, New York, and San Francisco, introducing millions outside India to this centuries-old celebration of devotion, community, and the chariots that carry the gods among their people.